Where India is concerned, it is only a departure from an established way of doing business that can yield results. And there are transformations underway, that of resilience and reliability when it comes to supply chains and trust and transparency when it comes to data. These offer real possibilities to build greater national capacities in various fields.

In the interim, it is essential that India is cautious about exposing its economy more substantially to unfair trade. This is not protectionism but economic self-defence. Resisting the lure of quick fixes is also necessary to build up domestic supply chains. When it comes to global competition, India's choices are best made in terms of what serves its interests well. These considerations must guide its choice of partners on connectivity initiatives and technology development as well.

The ability of India and China to cooperate in multilateral and plurilateral forums has naturally had some effect on their ties. Even now, there are some regional, developmental and political platforms that they co-inhabit. At the same time, the last decade has seen the emergence of new mechanisms dedicated to promoting the welfare of the global commons where the interests of the two neighbours diverge. It is helpful for the overall India–China relationship if the sum total of their diplomatic activities remains on the positive side of the ledger. But this is not that easy to realize given the differences on display when it comes to the expansion of the NSG, reform of the UN or the spread of the BRI.

Accommodating the rise of others while in the midst of your own cannot be easy. When it comes to strengthening multipolarity, India will obviously first evaluate how much of it applies in Asia itself. Similarly, when it comes to rebalancing, Indian choices will lean towards those options that accelerate its growth. But what should be clear is that a nation like India, which long viewed sovereign equality as a fundamental principle of international relations, will continue to do so in the times ahead.

Seen from a narrow bilateral perspective, it is not unexpected that the rise of India has been underplayed by China. Efforts to structurally shape its shared neighbourhood is naturally of deep interest to us. Prominent among that has been the BRI, one of whose corridors, we have noted, violates India's sovereignty. The maritime space is also beginning to undergo a noticeable transformation, one clearly not to India's benefit.

In all of this, the global commons has been left to the commitment of like-minded partners who share a sense of responsibility. India's interests